

Department of Digital Humanities
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This assignment is entirely my own work. Quotations from secondary literature are indicated by the use of inverted commas around ALL such quotations AND by reference in the text or notes to the author concerned. ALL primary and secondary literature used in this piece of work is indicated in the bibliography placed at the end, and dependence upon ANY source used is indicated at the appropriate point in the text. I confirm that no sources have been used other than those stated. I UNDERSTAND WHAT IS MEANT BY PLAGIARISM AND HAVE SIGNED THE DECLARATION CONCERNING THE AVOIDANCE OF PLAGIARISM. I UNDERSTAND THAT PLAGIARISM IS A SERIOUS EXAMINATIONS OFFENCE THAT MAY RESULT IN DISCIPLINARY ACTION BEING TAKEN.

If Marco Polo had a blog. A study of travel publishing in the digital age

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Abstract

This work aims to observe the influence of digital technologies in the production of travel narratives, highlighting challenges and opportunities that have arisen in this digital age for both the publishing industry and for travellers themselves. Analysing the specificities of the travel book genre (guidebooks, blogs, etc.), it aims to explore the changes in the audience, the rise of new authorship patterns, the technological shift and the cultural impact of digital disruption. This study is based on the responses to a questionnaire submitted in both English and Italian in order to explore similarities and differences between the two audiences. Furthermore, it includes the results of a focus group observation conducted with a sample of travellers. From data gathered it develops an ideal model for a platform integrating digital publishing and Travel 2.0 through a travel participated search engine tool tailored on digital travellers need as they emerged from the research.

I would like to thank Alessio, my everyday inspiration, for all his support and love.

CHAPTER 1

1.1 Travel and storytelling between tourism and publishing

Travel is a basic brick in the wall of civilization, a fundamental theme that transcends time and place. From Odysseus, to Marco Polo travel is necessary for cultural evolution in contemporary society (Larsen et al., 2007). The dichotomy between travel and tourism according to which travel is active, tourism is passive, travellers are good and tourists are bad, continues to raise ideological issues over the purpose and meaning of travel itself (Jack, 2003, p.283).

It is often overlooked that the act of tourism is a knowledge process not premeditated and sometimes unintentional. In fact only a quarter of travellers deliberately travel to learn something new (about the places they visit, about themselves). To undertake a trip is a process, which involves many preparatory activities and requires knowledge and a certain set of skills on the part of the tourists. Moreover, it is a remarkable example of self-motivated and self-funded informal lifelong learning (Falk et al., 2012). In fact, tourists travel voluntarily to fulfill personal interests, enjoying other environments to follow their personal needs and interests. The voluntary aspect of travelling is responsible for the different social value given to the time and effort put into this activity, compared to other goods and services (Prebensen et al., 2013).

Tourists' learning processes could be influenced by past experiences, personal attitudes and by the media, which might give rise to misleading representations of destinations, resulting in choices and stereotypes. However, tourism could also be considered a medium itself through which people produce knowledge and construct new visions for individual and social development.

The tourist experience has been divided by Wang et al., from a temporal perspective into three phases: (1) the anticipatory (2) the experiential and (3) the reflective (Wang et al., 2012, p.372).

In the first phase, tourists seek inspiration. At this stage they act like semioticians, constructing their destination image around well-defined signs or markers, which

identify people, things and places. Such signs are influenced by traditional media and the internet, and might create the “hyper-reality”: the myth of literary places established through TV and film locations, which influences tourists’ expectations and awareness (Eco, 1973).

According to Shaw et al., a destination image can be defined as: “the sum of beliefs, ideas and impressions that a person has, regarding a tourist destination” (Shaw et al., 2000). In fact, to portray their accurate personal image of a place, tourists combine formal and informal sources of information relying both on media representations and recommendations from family and friends, risking the failure of not feeling or perceiving whatever they expect.

In the tourism industry, technology is used to combine entertainment and information and represents the end of the dualism of leisure versus learning that in literature has been used to ignore the educational value of travelling (Falk et al., 2012). At the same time, technologies replacing of traditional activities with ICT counterparts encourages the reallocation of time to other leisure activities included travel (Mokhtarian et al., 2006).

The Internet has become the major platform to search for travel related information and to purchase travel services. According to recent studies, even though online and offline coexist as sources of information and for the purchase of tourist services (Skyscanner, 2014) there is a growing trend towards using the internet.

Web 2.0, when applied to the travel industry and its contents introduces participatory, collaborative and distributed practices which transform the way in which people plan, book and experience travels (Young Chung and Buhalis, 2010). The production of user-generated contents (UGC) and the increasing popularity of digital social networks have dramatically changed the way in which Internet users read and find information. Furthermore, Internet allows users to produce and share information generating the so-called electronic word-of-mouth (eWom), defined as being “any positive or negative statement made by potential, actual, or former customers about a product or company, which is made available to a multitude of people and institutions via the Internet” (Smith, 2012, p.103).

The Travel 2.0 environment encourages travellers to share their experiences and meet other travellers with the same interests, attitudes and lifestyles, promoting the empowerment of virtual communities. The use of tools to share photos and videos, to blog and share experiences and recommendations, as well as the use of maps and customer ratings in the inspiration and organization of trips, represent the most evident consequence of what is defined as Travel 2.0 (Parra-Lopez, 2011). According to the definition given by Xiang et al., Travel 2.0 includes “a range of new technological applications such as media and content syndication, mash-ups, AJAX, tagging, wikis, web forums and message boards, customer ratings and evaluation systems, virtual worlds (e.g., Second Life), podcasting, blogs, and online videos” (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010, p.181).

Travel 2.0 is increasing the number of players in the traditional process of travel contents production pushing the publishing industry to adapt quickly, changing its workflow process and its philosophy. The production of traditional contents such travel guidebooks, is a vertical process of knowledge transmission in which an

authority - the publisher (or the author according to the nature of the guide) – transmits the knowledge to the readers almost uni-directionally. The production of tourist guidebooks is an example of dis-embedding what was previously local knowledge (Jacobsen, 2003, p.79) by the authority of travel publishers and their authors. In Travel 2.0, this hierarchy blurs as publishers and readers become peers in the production of travel information, with travel guides becoming fellow travellers proposing their trip ideas (Sarfati-Romano, 2012, p.26).

The disruption in travel publishing is related to the changes and trends taking place in the tourism industry. The increasing popularity of short and frequent travels and the phenomenon of “staycations” - the trend of spending holidays in one’s home country rather than abroad, which involves day trips to local attractions - as a result of low-cost flights, is influencing travel storytelling (Google, 2014). These factors give publishers innovative challenges and opportunities to overcome the physical limits of weight and paper and answer travellers’ requests for more customised publications.

1.2 Travel guidebooks from the golden to the digital age

As a paradigm of travel writing, travel guides embody the most commercial narrative form for travel contents defining travel publishing as an autonomous sector. The genre of travel guidebooks is typified by referentiality, performativity and assemblage of rumours (Alacovska, 2013). Guidebooks are only partially read, but used intensely during the course of the holiday. They quickly become out of date due to the unsustainable and slow traditional publishing workflow and in many cases, they are too heavy to be carried on long journeys.

The emergence of this specific genre of travel narratives is connected with the rise of independent travellers demanding for useful and practical publications in order to explore new destinations (Jack, 2003). With the purpose of releasing the travellers from reliance on hired servants and guides (the most common ways to travel until the XIX Century) Karl Baedeker, the German pioneer of modern travel guides (Jack, 2003, p.283) launched the first travel guides for German tourists in 1823. Contemporary with Baedeker guides in Germany, in England Sir John Murray began to publish the first hand-guides for English speaking travellers discovering Europe (Lister, 1993). The analogue Murray and Baedeker guides were so capable to attract tourist trade that their archives are full of requests by hotels and restaurants to advertise their services in the popular publications. At the same time, common travellers used to share feedbacks about their experiences providing the publisher further recommendations in order to update future publications, thus preserving their usefulness and authenticity for future readers and travellers (Lister, 1993, p.8).

Travel publishing has been influenced by social and economic developments particularly dramatic after the Second World War with the rise of mass-tourism. This trend has lead a group of eight publishers to launch the first modern guidebooks: Rough Guide (www.roughguides.com), Lonely Planet (www.lonelyplanet.com), Insight Guides (www.insightguides.com), Frommer (www.frommers.com), Fodor (www.fodors.com) and the DK (www.dk.com) eyewitness, which have determined the contemporary landscape of travel publishing.

Guidebooks became such an influential symbol that travellers started to be identified by the type of guide they used (Jacobsen, 2003, p.79) to ride out local difficulties or face changes in destination preference.

This phase is considered the Golden Age of the genre, with travel publishing becoming a global business. The rise of the Travel 2.0 has dramatically influenced the role of traditional guides. A study conducted early in 2002 revealed that at that time, there were already 64 million individuals using the internet as a trip planning tool, so as to search for travel information online (Picard, 2003) suggesting the end of the domination of traditional guides. The increasing dominance of the Internet as a source of information is one of the major reasons for the decline of travel guidebooks as a source. The traditional guidebook publishers are required to answer the immediacy of updates and to harness the opportunities arising from the digital (Picard, 2003) adapting quickly to the new trends and audiences.

Digital and web 2.0 break down the boundaries between producers and consumers, undermining the supremacy of publishers in the production of contents and offering challenges to other players in the industry perhaps giving origins to new hierarchies. In fact, the curation of travel contents becomes a task for tourism industry, big media and web companies. These players promote the engagement of enthusiasts in the production of travel narratives as part of an overall marketing strategy, usually supported by a strong website ('How can digital publishing help the travel industry?', 2013) used as a hook to encourage the production of user generated contents. Web 2.0 democratizes and liberates cultural production, involving users in "produsage" (Bruns, 2008), promoting the work of the networked many in the form of collective intelligence, with the consequent decline of the influence of traditional travel publishers and their authors. Namely, changes and updates in the traditional process are tasks of the producer, whilst in a digital environment they become the tasks of users who have skills, ability, interest and enthusiasm to participate.

The increasing interest from big media and web companies towards the production of travel contents is redefining the boundaries between media companies and travel publishers. The emergence of the three C's in travel marketing: content, context, and conversations is mounting the influence of content marketing and curation strategies as the most effective ways to appear in search engines and promote brand loyalty encouraging favourable word of mouth among users (Pearo and Carroll, 2011). The following decline in sales of travel guidebooks and the increasing awareness of web and media companies towards the value of contents in search engines, has determined the acquisitions of Lonely Planet from BBC (www.bbc.com), Fodor's guides by Pearson (www.pearson.it) and Former's by Google (www.google.com) (Neri, 2012).

Although these acquisitions have helped travel publishers to survive, their potential has been limited by their own organizational rigidity. Soon after, both Google and the BBC have begun to re-sell travel guidebook brands starting their own production of curated travel contents seeking for new partnerships with the travel writers and influencers emerging in the web 2.0. Thus the slow giants of traditional travel publishing were left behind ('BBC News - BBC Worldwide sells Lonely Planet business at £80m loss', 2013).

Subsequently, travel publishers have begun to learn how not to sink in the digital age

developing tailored strategies which focus on specific audiences, usability and personalization. Moreover, digital is transforming travel publishing into a business that embraces the digitization of existing print contents and the creation of new digital products for travel contents.

Fodor, for instance, has launched the Fodor's London Travel Guide, a full-featured application for mobile and tablet which provides a large number of maps, color images, and links to allow users access places to visit, restaurants and other recommendations (Blumenthal, 2012). Frommer's, which works with an ebook design firm called Inkling (www.inkling.com), is focusing on a strategy linked to digital travel guides. Guides are available as ebooks designed for digital devices and organized in chapters allowing the reader to follow a different reading pattern which coincides with a different experiential key, such as: best sites in the region, a three-day trip and more tips about what is nearby, quick access to area maps, etc (Blumenthal, 2012). Lonely Planet's online shop offers the purchase of physical guides as well as Pdf's of individual chapters and entire books. Ebooks for tablets and e-readers are available through Amazon and other ebook retailers (www.lonelyplanet.com)

Lonely Planet's website, like that of its main travel guide competitor Rough Guides, is well designed and easy to navigate. It is organized according to the stages of the cycle of travel: inspiration, organization, experience and return. Both websites feature web-only contents such as traveller stories and travel advices, but unlike Rough Guides, Lonely Planet's website also has a very well-established forum, Thorn-Tree, where travellers interact and share stories with everyone visiting the site. The forum is a successful tool to encourage customers' loyalty around the brand thanks to the presence of a feedback button, which allow travellers to send information and update both to Lonely Planet authors and to the other member of the community (Dahlin 2001). Moreover, Lonely Planet is also using digital opportunities to produce new version of its platform creating contents for third parties in order to generate new revenue streams, for instance providing travel maps to Nokia mobile phones worldwide (Thoughtworks).

The opportunities provided by digital publishing for the travel genre are transforming guidebooks into more comprehensive publications, where contents are integrated with digital maps, social media and user generated websites, allowing travellers to build itineraries or make reservations (Blumenthal, 2012). Furthermore, the shift to digital publishing has allowed traditional travel guide publishers to promote narrative communities on the web, transforming travel into a collective narration, characterised by a customised approach in the delivery of travel experiences and travel contents (Seoane, 2012, p.13).

A 2013 study on the use of travel guidebooks, which was conducted among travel industry operators reveals that almost six out of ten UK holidaymakers (59%) used a hard copy traditional guidebook, and only 20% used an app (Press, 2013, p.29). Furthermore, 41% said they were keen to purchase a guidebook. The guidebook's superiority over the internet and apps is further confirmed as they poll 14%, as being the most useful source to plan a holiday for UK holidaymakers against the 3% achieved by travel blogs, travel apps and social media (Press, 2013, p.29).

Travel publishers are discovering and embracing creative ways to deliver new, rich and meaningful stories, to offer travellers stimulating and engaging contents promoting the interaction between authors and the audiences. In fact, browsing contents through digital devices, tablets and smartphones increase users' engagement, whereby the digital tools encourage collaboration, serial work and short forms of narration (Pearo and Carroll, 2011). At the same time, tourism firms are working hard to improve their contents production and are thus becoming media companies.

The benefit of digital publishing for travellers is the computer's ability to avoid or complement the ways in which users decide to interact. Technologies such as ePub 3.0, promises to be remarkable for travel publishing because of the script interface that allows to create new complex components and interaction like quizzes on destination ebooks or and other interactive functions for apps and ebooks. Hyper-links are appreciated by audiences and their presence makes guidebooks more readable than they are in print, facilitating the immediacy of actions such as searching for a restaurant or directions to a top attraction (Schratz, 2012). Furthermore, the digital format saves space mounting the relevance of texts and contents in a guide setting new priorities for travel publishers from a pure digitisation of catalogues to the development of user-targeted digital contents (Dahlin, 2001).

The increasing influence of the digital on travellers has pushed towards the creation of new publishing products, which combine travel guides, maps and literature delivered as ebooks, websites and apps for smartphones and tablets. Subsequently, big publishers and media companies have launched or improved their travel sections, giving rise to a variety of editorial products across platforms. Among the others, BBC Travel, for instance was launched after 2010 as part of a BBC digital strategy and in one year saw a 20% growth in user's engagement (Sweeney, 2013).

Historical brands such as Baedeker have become part of a larger travel editorial project in partnership with Lonely Planet innovating 3d visualization, infographics and geo tagged maps ('Baedeker Reiseführer | Reiseführer', n.d.).

Moreover, digital publishing services suppliers like Yudu (www.yudu.com), which help travel companies provide their readership with ways to quickly access content such as maps and local guides without internet connection, are growing in popularity ('How can digital publishing help the travel industry?', 2013) and improving the publishing role of non-traditional players. The web is transforming travel companies in media companies, which produce curated contents in an easy and web tailored way taking from traditional travel publishers.

1.3 Travel publishing scenario - Italian and English market

Today, travel information has become multichannel and mainstream and can be found in travel magazines, tourism related websites, social networks, blogs, user-generated reviews and in a variety of other platforms and publications.

Travel is one of the fields which is most likely to benefit from digital publishing because its narration takes different forms, from textual to visual and beyond (Oppenheim and Randall, 2002). Some of the most crucial challenges currently faced from digital publishing are interoperability, integration of various sources, accessibility, usage, functionality, storage, preservation and archiving. Digital reading

devices are able to contain large amounts of content and answer the issue of accessibility, overcoming the problem of having an Internet connection and the concern of physical limits deriving from traditional publishing.

Digital readers' requirements are also evolving. Ten years ago they were more concerned with readability and portability (Oppenheim and Randall, 2002), whilst travel readers in the digital age have three predominant motivations: to stay up to date, pursue their personal interests, and finally, to find everything available on the topic of their interest in each format (Wills and Wills, 1996). Studies show that one of the real strengths of ebooks is the way they can support both "ad hoc," and routine reading practices in new ways. In particular, the lightweight form of e-readers, the common presence of smartphones, the ability to pick and choose from a library or download new contents, means that e-reading is tailored to suit many fields including that of travel (Hupfeld et al., 2013, p.16).

The last report on the Italian publishing market reveals an increasing trend for sales of digital contents +6,4% against a general decline (-8,4%) of the profitability of the sector in general (Aie, 2013). In 2013, the UK book market fell 2% despite a 19% growth in digital sales (The Publishers Association, 2014). After years of decline across the overall publishing sector, some UK travel publishers in 2013 saw growth for the first time in many years. The decline in the overall market for guides and maps also slowed down. In regards to World Travel guides, which represent the largest category, sales were only down by 4.7% in 2013 (compared with -7%, -12%, -10% and -12% respectively in 2009-12) (Mesquita, 2014). According to these figures the two digital publishing markets are facing similar challenging trends, which might be encouraging for travel publishers (Pan et al., 2007). Though, the current research is conducted among web-based survey to Italian and English speakers, it might include contributions from English speakers not necessarily from UK. However this insight on UK digital publishing market gives a hint of the set of travel contents available for English speakers.

CHAPTER 2

2.1 The creation of travel contents in the digital age

The shrink in the number of travel guidebooks published in Italy and the UK does not reflect less interest on travel contents but rather, the fact that the internet is dramatically taking over publishers as a source providing travel information (Mantarro, 2014). In Italy, in 2007, the people connected to the web were about 24,000.000, and half of these individuals were accessing travel websites (Franchi, 2007). In the same year, 2.5 million out of a total of 21.4 million Italians, had read at least one travel and leisure magazine. Travel and online travel bookings are the second most commonly searched topics on the web with local information including transport receiving 52%, Google search with the key word travel hit 51% and the key word holidays 46% (Franchi, 2007).

The multiplicity of online publications has increased the possibility for publishers to create different contents to reach different audiences and to make things discoverable (Rasley, 2012). A TripAdvisor tourism report has classified contemporary travellers

into three groups: the millennials, the families and the retirees. All three groups have different levels of familiarity with digital tools and the Internet and express the need to access different kinds of information through different sources. This classification is based on a generational and budget distinction, where millennials are the independent travellers, the youngest, with a medium budget, familiar with the Internet and mobile technologies seeking personalized experiences. Families on the other hand, are very careful to budget and seek for breaks rather than experiences. They are more likely to address online travel agencies and communities. The third group is that of the retirees, who are less budget sensitive and seek culturally significant experiences. Though connected, they are the less familiar with digital tools (IPSOS, 2014). Each audience asks for different travel contents, expecting to find useful and customized information as well as stories across various devices.

Since the digital age has involved web companies and tourism firms in the field of travel contents production, they are acting as publishers, promoting travel blogs and storytelling projects, curating contents as a strategy to harness the opportunities offered by digital publishing. Skyscanner for instance, one of the largest tourism web companies, which helps travellers find personalized solutions to flying between destinations, has been awarded as the best website for travel and leisure in Italy ('Skyscanner vince il premio Sito web dell'anno. | Skyscanner', 2013) thanks to its blog and the curation of topics and storytelling patterns which work as a source of inspiration for travellers. Its offer includes a web-magazine, news, travel tips, it hosts travel bloggers, offers user reviews and publishes user generated travel journals. In Italy, BlaBlaCar (www.blablacar.com), one of the most successful examples of the sharing economy, which exploits the web and the interaction among users to share routes in private vehicles, has partnered with the Italian publisher of the newspaper La Stampa, in order to create a storytelling project collecting travel stories in an ebook available in Pdf and ePub formats ('Ebook Bla Car').

Moreover, traditional publishers work alongside local tourist boards and tourism industry players in travel storytelling. An interesting example of a digital, travel publishing project promoted by a scholarly institution is that of ReNom (www.renom.univ-tours.fr), an initiative developed by Tours University in France. Its aim is to provide navigational tools, usable by the wider public, for exploring places and characters in the works of Rabelais and Ronsard. The project works by associating key texts of the two Renaissance authors with a system of geo-references and a series of fact sheets corresponding to the places and characters mentioned in the texts. Multi-criteria search options and an interactive map, enable users to acquire information on the places and characters mentioned in Rabelais and Ronsard's works in their geographical contexts. Designed for tourists and literature lovers, as well as scholars, the geo-referenced texts may be downloaded as ePub files and are thus available offline. This project seeks to encourage a form of literary tourism that is at once fun and instructive, developing the region's touristic potential ('Renom', 2013).

On the one hand, the web has released and allowed creativity in storytelling but at the same time it produces too much content. In this modern context where everyone is curating and tailoring stories, the publishers can operate as filters of contents generated on the web and develop commercial strategies and techniques for disseminating the products, spotting good stories and helping quality narrations to emerge (Rastelli, 2014). Moreover, digital publishing is enabling old paper archives

and their content to be curated in order to create new stories and raise cultural issues with the aid of interactive maps and multimedia contents (Rastelli, 2014).

VisitBritain (www.visitbritainsuperblog.com) in the UK and ParlamidiTER (blog.travelemiliaromagna.com) in Italy, are two relevant examples of public tourism promoters using digital publishing techniques to create local storytelling collecting and editing crowd sourced multimedia contents together with traditional ones. Users' engagement through social media, together with digital storytelling such as blogging and the production of crowd sourced contents, might be an effective way to use travel 2.0 to improve travel publishers' brand loyalty strategies and to ensure an innovative future for the genre (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010, p.151).

2.2. Travel blogs

Travel 2.0, has endorsed the development of narrative symbolic representations, before and during vacations, used to obtain information about the destination, share experiences and compare services, among which the most popular are travel blogs (Pudliner, 2007, p.49). Blogs are a form of digital storytelling which has increased in use and popularity as a consequence of mass tourism and the rise of the Internet as a primary source of information for travellers (Pan et al., 2007). Travel narration patterns have always been influenced by the changes occurring in travel perception, which are determined by social, economic, technological and cultural factors. Traditionally, travel publishing is associated with the production of editorial products, such as travel guidebooks, brochures etc., whereby with the rise of the internet, dismissed storytelling patterns traditionally limited to the personal sphere such as the journaling of travel adventures, are transformed into public knowledge (Pudliner, 2007). The on-line self-publication of personal actions and experiences as a blog, delivers a unique interpretation of the world generating a set of information and representations of places, which promote the creation of communities among like-minded people sharing common interests (Blood, 2002a).

Travel blogs have proliferated, as people around the world have become keener to share their own experiences and to seek inspiration for their next adventures. On the web there are an estimated 200 million travel-related blogs (Bennett, 2008). Weblogs, since they appeared, have taken several forms, from links with snippets of information to digitized journals. The most obvious form of blogs in tourism appears to be the publication of travel stories and online recommendations from travellers. The authors opportunity to expand including multimedia materials such as pictures, streaming videos, geo-tags and interactive tools enables the reader to explore and evaluate vast amounts of information quickly (Pudliner, 2007, p.46).

Contemporary, tourist bloggers are "rapidly becoming the travel opinion leaders of the electronic age" (Litvin et al., 2008, p. 466). Blogs are, by definition, highly personal and not subject to the editorial controls that apply to a guidebook (Bennett, 2008). Therefore, travellers tend to use and trust blogs' information when searching for travel information, tips and when choosing travel suppliers and destinations (Sigala, 2009, p. 224). This is because the information they share is based on first-hand, authentic travel experiences and is perceived by users as unbiased, if compared with traditional tourist information sources (Zehrer, 2011, p.108). Blogs' trustworthiness and success are influencing trends in tourism and developing new

forms of narration and users participation among the travel industry and travel publishing (Vrana and Zafiropoulos, 2010).

Travel blogs writing style features are the most common in Internet: short and concise commentaries to allow readers to make future explorations. The particular unique display of bloggers describing and depicting an intimacy with the landscape visited at a certain moment in time, becomes a relevant source of information for travellers (Pudliner, 2007).

Furthermore, blogs are an inexpensive means to gather rich, authentic and unsolicited customer feedback and to spread eWom (Pan et al., 2007). Therefore, the tourism industry and travel related companies are encouraging the presence and participation of bloggers to their events, hosting blog posts in their information platforms. In addition, semantic network and content analysis applied to travel blogs can reveal destinations perceptions helping tourist layers to identify strengths and weaknesses of their marketing strategies (Wang, 2011, p.504).

In Italy and UK, travel blogs are attempting to develop similar narrative patterns. In both countries there are bloggers who have become recognized for their influence on the travel industry (Jobling, 2013). They often privilege a crossmedia narration by beginning with writing blogs, adding pictures and then subsequently running their own YouTube channels. YouTube is an ideal place to explore how travellers interact with video content. According to a recent study conducted by Google, every month more than one billion people visit YouTube and two out of three U.S. consumers watch online travel videos when they are considering taking a trip (Crowel et al., 2014).

Furthermore, travel bloggers are authors who are able to effectively manage social accounts. One of the keys of their success is the wise management of the potential offered by Facebook, Twitter, Instagram and YouTube, and the constant interaction with their followers. The popularity of bloggers has turned the traditional influential model of publishing upside down. In fact, publishers today need web stars such as travel bloggers to re-launch their businesses as well as brands in travel industry (Bennett, 2008). Travel bloggers are increasingly becoming popular and influential across media: from TV travel shows to the columns of top-rated magazines. This trend suggests once again, that digital tools are revitalizing the publishing industry. *Turisti per caso* (www.turistipercaso.it) is an example of a broadcast TV show which has become a successful blog and a community demonstrating that the crossmediality of travel contents is increasing together with the nature and number of travel writers. The influence of some of the most popular English blogs has been measured according to the number of retweets and the following engagement bloggers generate. What emerged is that niche travel bloggers, targeted to a specific theme or destination (such as baldhiker.com and aluxurytravelblog.com) are more likely to create traffic and engagement, thus they are considered more influential (Barker, 2013).

At the same time, the traditional model of travel writers or travel journalists, which was writing for guidebooks, travel magazines or for the travel columns of newspapers, has been disrupted. Today, travel writers input their content into a CMS system from the road and publishers are able to deliver it across several channels at once. Hence, the differences between writing for a travel blog or a traditional travel publisher are disappearing.

2.3 Travel publishing among communities and coproduction

One of the most difficult and time consuming issues that travel guide publishers face in the digital age is keeping their books, apps, and ebooks relevant and up to date. This means that new editions and updates must appear regularly, and on an international scale. Users generated contents have become crucial for travellers, transforming the web into an environment in which travel information is constantly updated thanks to the production of new contents without the limits of traditional publishing. The Travel 2.0 has threatened the traditional professional autonomy of publishers and transformed the nature of travel contents and services offered. In fact, as soon as travellers had approached the Internet, virtual communities had become an important source of electronic word of mouth, converting personal experiences into trustworthy sources of information. Virtual communities are asynchronous channels which could be accessed at different times both by authors and readers and allow similar-minded people to share experiences, exchange information, to entertain with peers (Wang, 2011, p.504) and eventually, produce new forms of travel contents.

There are different motivations, which encourage virtual community members to engage in on-line activities. These include the exchange of information, the purpose of providing support to other like-minded people and the exchange of ideas with other members which usually requires guidance from a moderator (Wang and Yu, 2002, p.412).

The successful Lonely Planet Forum “Thorn Tree”, is a user generated source of information but also a platform rich in group communities and shared, updated contents. Lonely Planet Thorn Tree adapts user know-how within the conventions of the guidebook genre combining the information patterns, typical of guidebooks, with the emerging digital storytelling narratives. Harnessing the creativity of the many individuals involved in the community, has changed the nature of Lonely Planet from a travel guidebook publisher into a travel information business (Alacovska, 2013).

Conversation in online traveller communities is a productive force: when the book is obsolete, the community is fresh. In a community, participants are perceived as fellow users, with no intentions to manipulate the readers, generating trustworthiness. Travel communities encourage a new genre of travel storytelling, taking advantage of the potential offered by digital audiences and tools. To this extent, travel related companies have a great interest in maintaining and harboring online communities because they produce low cost contents in the form of rumours, word of mouth, conversation and stories, thus affecting significantly travel decisions (Alacovska, 2013, p.55).

Nevertheless, comments and reviews generated across forums and communities represent a new frontier for travel contents, which publishers should deal with, in order to promote brand-loyalty and provide updated contents. The virtual communities are the ideal environments to re-think the production of contents and the collaboration among authors.

Collaborative forms of authorship, better known as Wiki APPROFONDIRE, have originated two crowd sourced travel projects known worldwide: Wikitravel

(www.wikitravel.org) and Wikivoyage (www.wikivoyage.org). The difference between travel wikis and the more popular wiki encyclopedia Wikipedia, is the focus on the production of practical and useful information to visit particular places and find most relevant landmarks, following a pattern traditionally accomplished by travel guidebooks ('L'intricata storia del nuovo Wikivoyage - Il Post', 2013).

Wikivoyage is a platform, which allows users to create their own ebooks in Pdf and ePub formats, collecting the articles and offering them also a service of print-on demand. Project updating is completely voluntary and apart from Wikitravel, which allows advertising, is completely ad-free. Wikivoyage has developed a partnership with Open Street Maps to develop a mobile version supporting scrollable web maps. The site's content is filled out with the open source Wiki tool that lets users create, update, and edit any article on the site. Data is available in creative commons and ready to be released in mashups and other formats. The characteristic of both projects is that they answer the questions of what to do and what to see, providing practical tips on sleeping, moving, eating. There is no mention of history, economy or other in-depth topics.

The Wikis are a great resource for crowd sourced contents and are very informative, but they can be exceedingly dry and can suffer from a lack of resources that might otherwise be available to commercial enterprises (Schaal, 2012).

Afar (www.afar.com) for instance, is a creative platform, which allows users to use pictures and 1,500 characters to create their "highlights" (destinations recommendations). Launched in 2013, it already covers 7,000 destinations with 55,000 crowd sourced highlights.

Moreover, there are online community marketplaces, which have embraced the use of online reviews such as AirBnB (<https://www.airbnb.com>), to produce user generated contents across various formats. AirBnB, one of the major firms in the sharing economy, puts together private hosts and travellers around the world, in order to build personalised experiences for travellers. The company is developing interesting digital content strategies included special guides. The author of the AirBnB guide is the host, who is enabled to promote its accommodation by tagging relevant landmarks and sightseeing destinations in close proximity, on a map. Hosts advertise and guests review, and this becomes a relevant source of information for people organizing their trips.

The opportunity of accessing fellow travellers' reviews and the human dimension offered by digital is opening up new perspectives for tourism. The connection between personalisation and storytelling is tight, therefore curation of contents and publishers skills play a fundamental role. The strategic relevance of curated contents for search engines in the process of searching travel information makes discoverable the customised knowledge required from users. Moreover, it would be useful to conduct further studies to analyse contents produced by travellers in their reviews in order to develop a quantitative measure of expressed reviewer innovativeness, and to examine its effect on the helpfulness of the communicated advice (Pan and Zhang, 2011, p.599).

2.4 Travel contents and social networks

The internet mediates tourists understanding, allowing them to portray and share their experiences producing real-time information through social media (Zettler, 2012). Social media are an integrated part of the travel experience with infinite possibilities to engage consumers and locals, influence experience of travel, gather information, share stories, and make all this content available in the public domain (Pearo and Carroll, 2011).

Travel is the most shared topic in Facebook with dedicated features, such as the “traveling to” feature, the star-rated system for hotels and restaurants, or even Graph Search that helps users “find people, places and things”. Pinterest is rumored to be launching a new travel product called “choose your own adventure”, aiming to enlarge its role in the travel business. Its most recent feature, launched at the end of 2013, is called “Place Pins”. It is a function, which allows users to get more location-based information and itineraries on various boards. Nevertheless, travel appears the most popular topic shared through pictures and pins (Zettler, 2012).

TripAdvisor, has also become a remarkable social media during the trip planning phase. In fact, users look at other tourists’ comments and materials alongside various stages of travel process. While in the post-travel phase, travellers produce reviews and other contents to share their experiences (Zehrer, 2011). TripAdvisor has seen its usage increase exponentially in the past year with some 100 million comments written between 2000 and 2012, while 50 million were written in 2013 alone (Gonzalo, 2014).

Instagram, which now has over 200 million active users, has become a *de facto* tool for most travel destinations launching hashtags to encourage locals and tourists alike to upload and share their best meaningful pictures (Gonzalo, 2014). The “Instagram effect” is a kind of social media envy, which has a powerful impact on travel behaviour. It offers inspiration, personalization and represents an avenue towards self-discovery, enabling travellers to become more dynamic and informed citizens (Gonzalo, 2014). Further to this, LinkedIn which is turning itself into a fully-fledged publishing platform, having now reached the 300 million user milestone (Gonzalo, 2014), hosts groups for travel enthusiasts, travel publishers, writers and bloggers. Among the original and most popular travel social networks there are Travelbuddy (www.travbuddy.com) and Couchsurfing (www.couchsurfing.org), based on user generated contents, promoting interaction among locals and travellers.

The increasing access to social media through mobile devices determines an increasingly mobile trend in the production and delivery of travel contents (Pfennigschmidt and Tsigka, 2010). Although Facebook provides specific services for companies allowing them to write longer posts and share photos, Twitter is better built for quick reference questions and links to contents. According to a survey conducted across travel publishers in 2013 on their use of social networks, all major US travel publishing brands with the exception of Rick Steves (www.ricksteves.com) were more active on Twitter than Facebook as shown in the graphic below (Fig.1) (Shankman, 2013). However the data measuring social engagement, the replies to Twitter, and listening to users, revealed that publishers are not particularly active (Fig.

2) suggesting a use of social networks more as a showcase than as a platform for interaction with audiences.

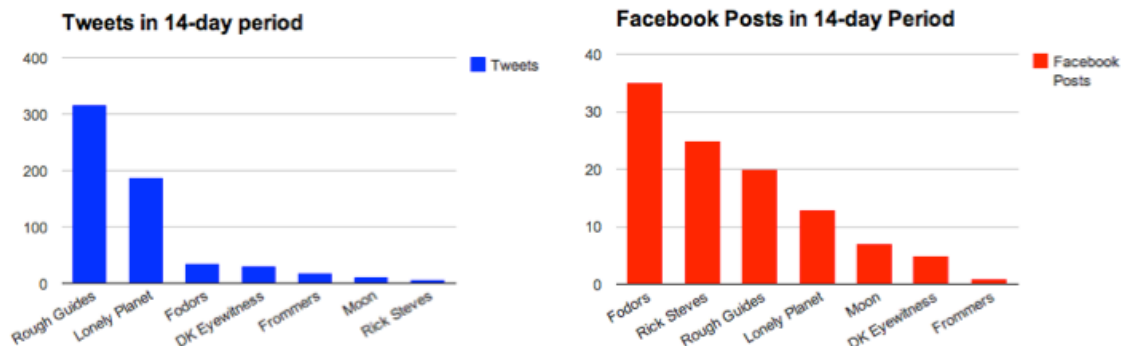


Fig.1 US travel publishers tweets and FB post in 14 days (Shankman, 2013, p.3).

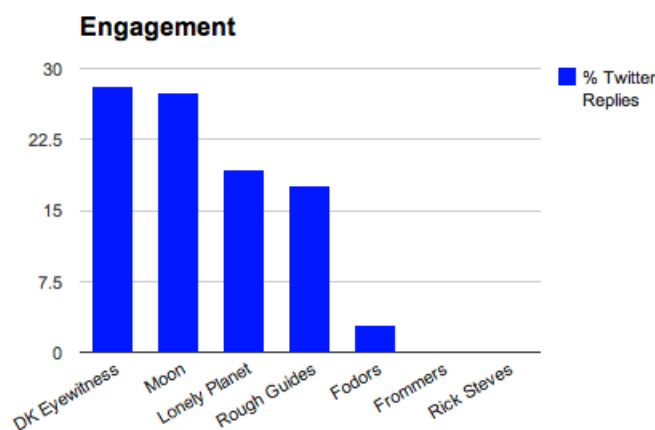


Fig. 2 US travel publishers Twitter engagement in 14 days (Shankman, 2013, p.4).

The trends observed in the brands' approach to social media suggest that a travel publisher's website will no longer have "products and services" tabs, but rather "Showcase" pages where travel content is shared (Pearo and Carroll, 2011).

Today, Facebook, Twitter, Trip Advisor, Pinterest and YouTube are among the most popular social networks, albeit they might be replaced by other sites over time. However, the trends of the skeptical consumers interacting with each other and searching for rich and wide array of content in tourism and travel publishing, is believed to extend into the future (Pearo and Carroll, 2011).

CHAPTER 3

3.1 "If Marco Polo had a blog: travel culture in the digital age". A social research

A crucial part of this dissertation is represented by the attempt to conduct research in order to understand users' approaches towards the travel process and their interaction with travel publications and information sources. In particular, the analysis

wanted to observe users' awareness on the use of different tools in the main processes of shaping travel culture and experience. The research method used is that of a questionnaire where the researcher is "invisible" to the traveller. This method minimizes the issues of respondents distorting their activity to appear socially successful, competent or as appealing individuals (Phillimore & Goodson, 2004).

Two web-based questionnaires were launched at different times. This action was carried out in order to analyse two different linguistic audiences (Italian and English) whose travel publishing markets have significant differences as pointed out in chapter 2. The questionnaire was originally designed in Italian and a parallel translation was used to convert it into English. The survey in Italian was published at the end of April in 30 Facebook groups related to an influential national tour operator (www.avventurenelmondo.it) as well as in other Facebook groups for travel enthusiasts in the country. The survey was used as a hook to recruit volunteers for the focus group and at the same time, to collect data and feedback in a less committing and more anonymous way. Although not every eligible member of the target population has an equal chance of being selected, using this method permits to assemble a significant sample conveniently. The use of self-selecting respondents means that although the questionnaire responses would prove indicative, we could make no claim that they were representative of the target population as a whole. These limits and following readings made necessary the launch of a second questionnaire in English, which was disseminated across the main English-speaking traveller's communities and blogs at the end of June.

The study of Facebook travelogues, groups and on-line forums was initiated by a search in Facebook using such phrases as "travelogues" and "travel writers". An invitation to answer the survey was published in a number of group discussions in the Lonely Planet Forum Thorn Tree. Twitter was also used to spread this survey as accounts belonging to independent travellers and travel bloggers were contacted. At the same time, English native speakers who were randomly met in travel forums or in social networks were invited to participate. A very useful tool has been LinkedIn, where a link to the survey was posted in groups containing in the name the words "travel", among which there were professional tourism and travel writers networks. Some groups proved to be a good showcase and the shared link to the questionnaire created engagement generating enthusiasm and participation among groups' members. The English version of the survey presents some differences from the Italian version. In particular, it includes additional questions to measure the importance and the influence of each of the options available using a five-point scale, ranging from less to more influential. Therefore, this measure is not considered as statistics whereas it might be used to confirm interpretation arising from the data gathered.

The questionnaire contained a first section, used to draw a demographic of the participants with basic questions regarding their gender, age, profession and education. The survey is structured following the three stages identified in the process of travel: inspiration, travel and post experience (Tab.1).

Tab.1 "If Marco Polo had a blog. The questionnaire

SECTION 1 INSPIRATION
Q1 Which one of these tools has influenced your choice of undertaking a journey?
Q2 In which of these places have you found hints for undertaking a new journey?
SECTION 2 CHOICE OF DESTINATION
Q3 How do you choose your destination?
SECTION 3 ORGANIZATION OF A TRIP Useful tools to plan a trip
Q4 Which tools do you use to organize your journey?
SECTION 4 DURING THE TRAVEL Devices and contents in a trip
Q5 Which devices and tools do you carry with you when you travel?
Q6 Which contents do you produce when you travel?
SECTION 5 POST TRAVEL
Q7 Which contents do you produce once back?

237 responses were collected on-line over a four-week period. A larger part of the respondents, more than 70% fell between the ages of 31 and 55. The majority (more than 52%) holds a master's degree. At the beginning of August, 156 responses were collected for the English questionnaire. Females were the most representative, with a bachelor or a master degree. 29% aged between 31 and 40, mostly employed in the PR/communication sector and within the academy. The two demographics considered are mostly made up of females (70% in the Italian questionnaire and 60% in the English one).

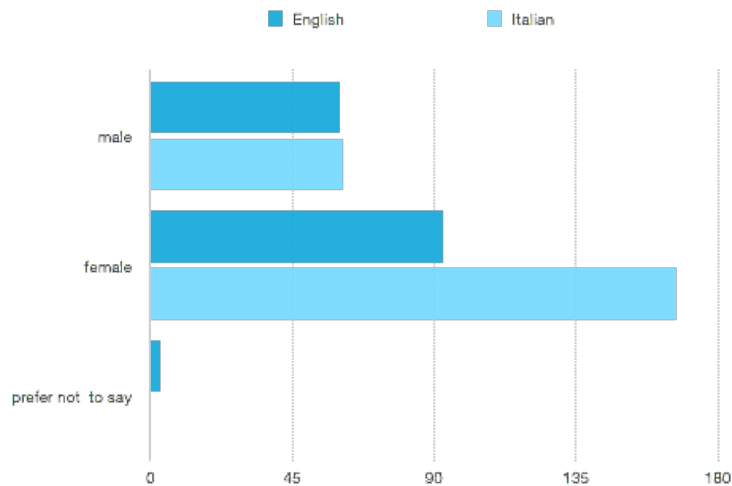


Fig 3. Gender distribution in English and Italian samples

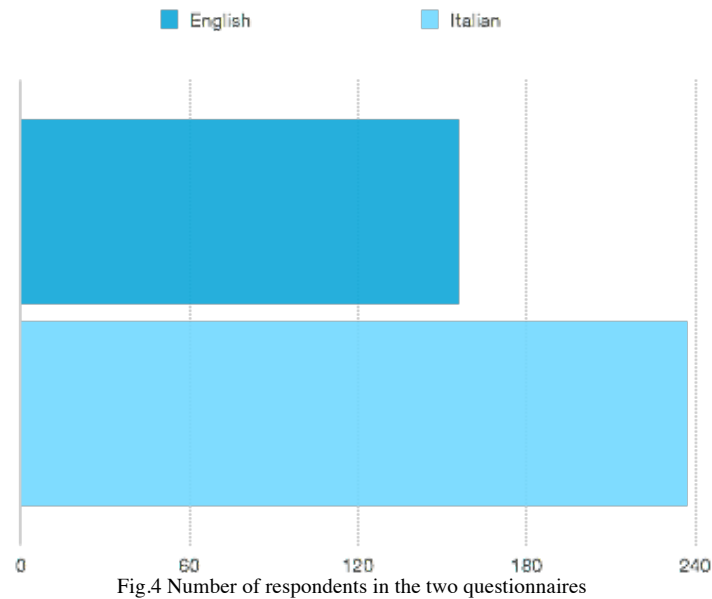


Fig.4 Number of respondents in the two questionnaires

The age range of the English sample is spread from a 39% total of people ranged 18-25 and 26-30 with the largest percentage of 28%, aged 31-40 and an almost similar 16% scored by users ranged 41-55. On the other hand the Italian sample is older, with 73% of respondents aged between 31-55.

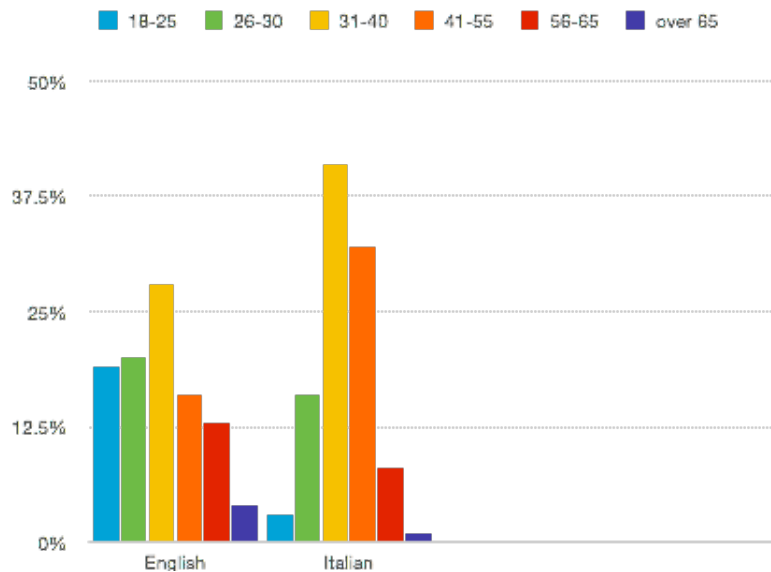


Fig. 5 Age group comparison in the two samples

The first part of the questionnaire investigates the role played by certain tools, both digital and analogue tools as sources of inspiration for travellers. According to Maser and Weiermair, in tourism, “information can be treated as one of the most or even the most important factor, influencing and determining consumer behavior” (Pearo and Carroll, 2011, p.7).

Although the two questionnaires present some slight vagueness (i.e. in the Italian survey books and ebooks are classified together as well as advertising for web, TV and radio), results showed that word of mouth influences 66% of English respondents as opposed to 59% of the Italians. Books are the second major source for both

audiences whereas for the Italian travellers, TV and web documentaries are most frequently indicated as the first source (67%). This trend is partially confirmed by the success of documentaries used as integrated content platforms, such as *Adventures in Wild California* in 2000, with a remarkable number of users accepting to pay to watch it on-line (Google, 2013). On the scale of 1 to 5 books polled 4, ebooks only 1, magazines 4, film 3, advertising 2, TV doc 4 and web doc 3, web ads 1, travel websites 4. Word of mouth is the only source to score a 5, being the most influential, confirming trends rising from the questionnaire.

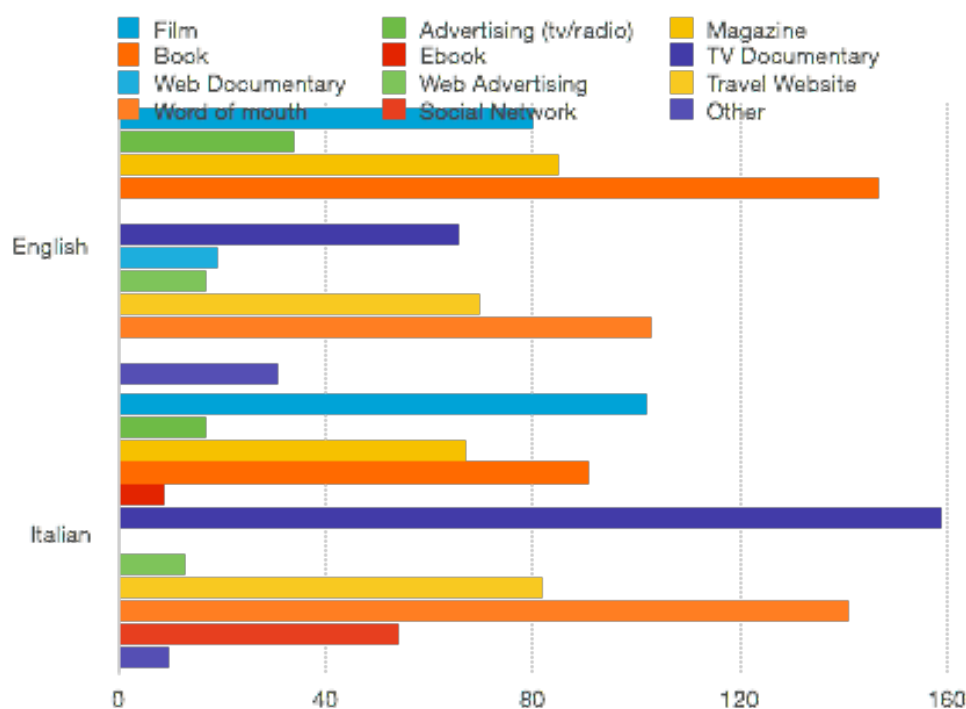


Fig.6 Sources of inspiration in the two samples

Among the sources of inspiration, Internet polls gained 72% among Italian participants followed by bookstores. For 63% of the English audience it is the most inspirational place followed by more specific indications of other online resources such as travel websites and on-line communities. This trend is confirmed by figures revealed on a Google Travel report 2013 in which the web is seen as the main inspiring place and source (Google, 2013). In a scale of influence, travel websites and Internet polls came in around 4 and 5, whereas ebook stores significantly appear as the least inspiring places with the highest percentage of 1.

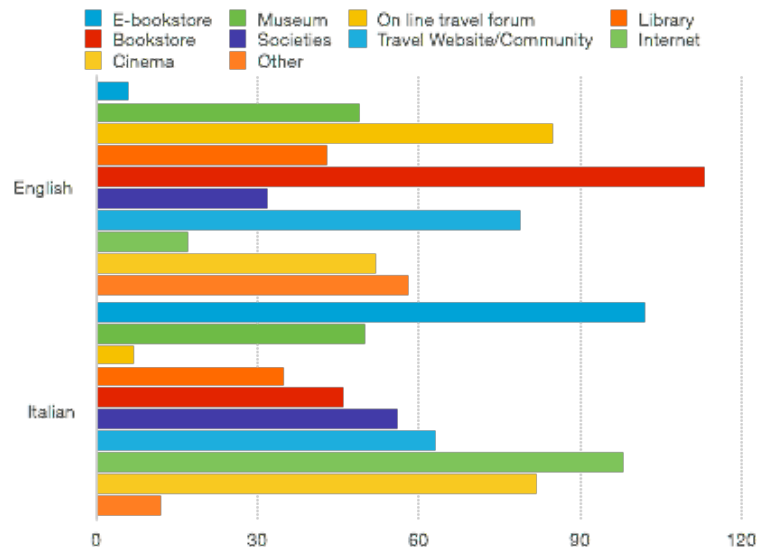


Fig.7 Inspiring places in the two samples

The choice of destination is influenced by the information searched in the Internet for 83% of Italians and 82% of English. However, these figures suggest that people would be likely to trust editorial contents published in the web as travel guides followed by friends' advice and reviews in TripAdvisor and other online communities. Once again this trend is confirmed by the scale measure with Internet and word of mouth polling 5, followed by on line communities polling mostly 3 and 4. Less influential are traditional operators such as travel agencies and travel societies.

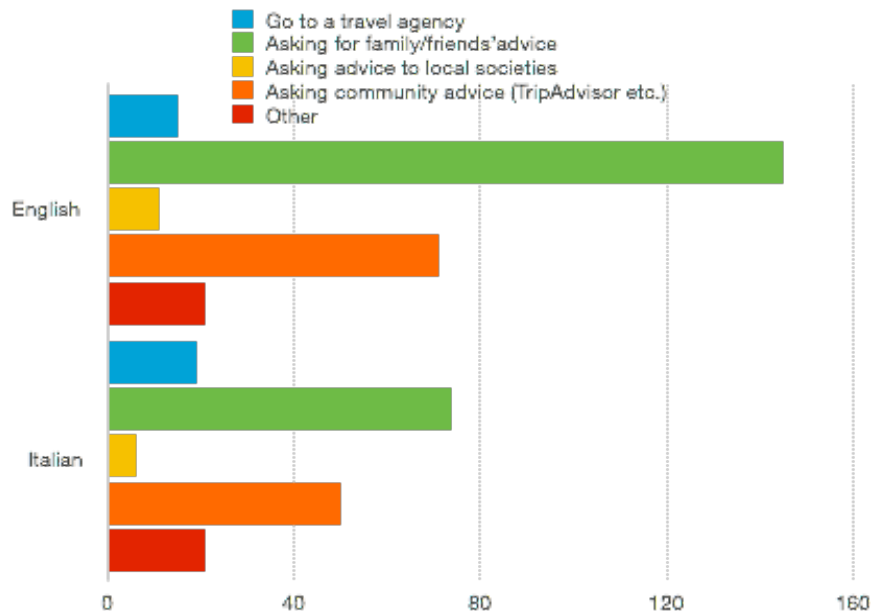


Fig. 8 Choosing a destination in the two samples

Despite the on-going controversy surrounding peer review websites, including the legitimacy and authenticity of reviews and the fact that sometimes the vast amount of user generated info available on TripAdvisor is too difficult to navigate, respondents relies mostly on online recommendations to plan their holidays (Ayeh, 2013). TripAdvisor and other online reviews count for 68% for the Italian audience whereas blogs and forums polled 69% among English participants. Guidebooks score a significant number of answers in the Italian questionnaire whereas they were not very

meaningful in the English. A significant percentage of the Italian sample (13%) declared use of other devices and content that do not belong to one of the categories listed in the questionnaire, which was tailored to include the most common travel traditional and digital contents and related devices.

In the organization of a trip, online recommendations dominate polling around 4 and 5 with the highest percentage of votes. Many tools and devices are seen as significantly influential polling 4 such as travel guidebooks, user generated reviews such as TripAdvisor, on line travel communities, travel books (3-4) and travel ebooks (2-4) whereby Smartphone travel apps polled 3.

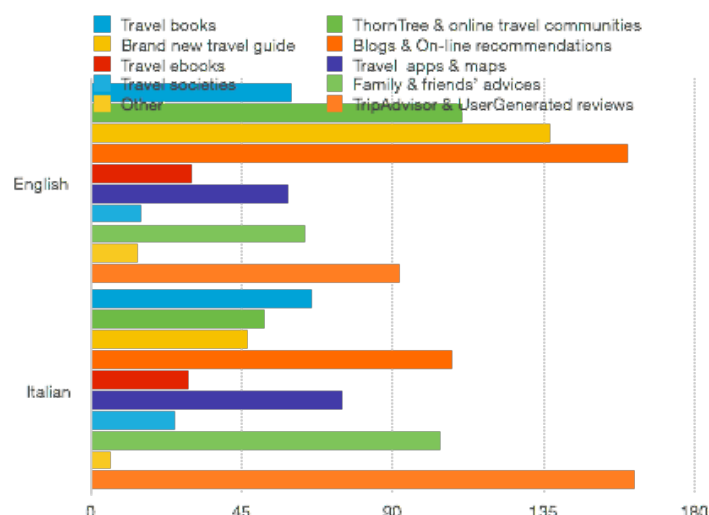


Fig.9 Tools used to organize a journey in the two samples

Finally, in regards to the process of undertaking a trip, devices and contents carried by users during their trips are also an important insight for publishers. Italian participants are more analogue rather than digital, with 67% of them carrying travel guides, polling higher than the number of users carrying a smartphone (63%). The last category is the majority among the English (78%), followed by those carrying digital maps (55%). This figure might suggest that maps are intended as smartphone apps. In the influential scale, smartphones and maps hit the top followed by on line contents, local sources, apps and travel guidebooks polling 4. Travel books and ebooks in general are not seen as influential contents. Moreover, tablets and e-readers proved to be the least influential devices.

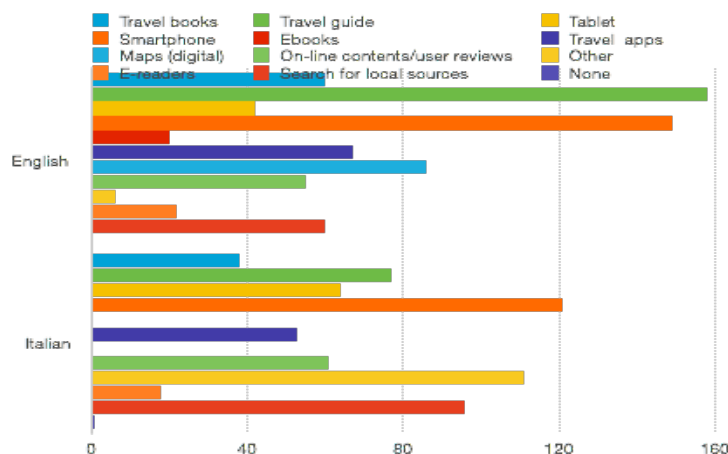


Fig.10 Devices and tools used during a trip in the two samples

The answers related to the questions investigating the production of contents during the trip, present some bias. In fact, in the first questionnaire, the Italian one, blogs, journals and the production of video and photo were listed in the same option. This choice was made because at first, all these were considered forms of storytelling without distinction. Afterwards, the various forms of storytelling were separated as different options in the English questionnaire. Regardless of this vagueness, 48% of Italian travellers produce some form of storytelling, whereas 90% of English travellers produce visual contents and afterwards update their social. Narrative contents such as blogs, polled a low percentage forerun by personal journals.

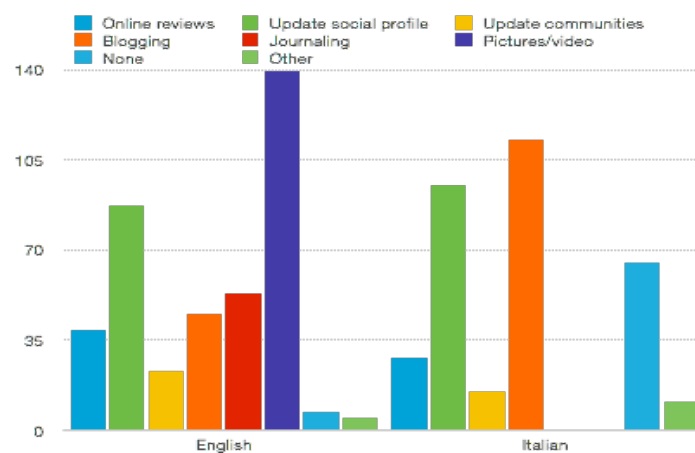


Fig.11 Contents produced during the trip in the two samples

Post-travel, the majority of English respondents are likely to share their experiences on line through social media (71%) and communities, whereas 57% of Italian respondents are more likely to produce some narratives in the form of blogs, journals, photos etc. The most biased data regarding the frequency of the activities refers to the production of online reviews polling the highest percentage of 1 but also a significant number of 5. The same bias can be observed in the frequency of sharing experiences with communities and forums. The less common activity is the curation of blogs.

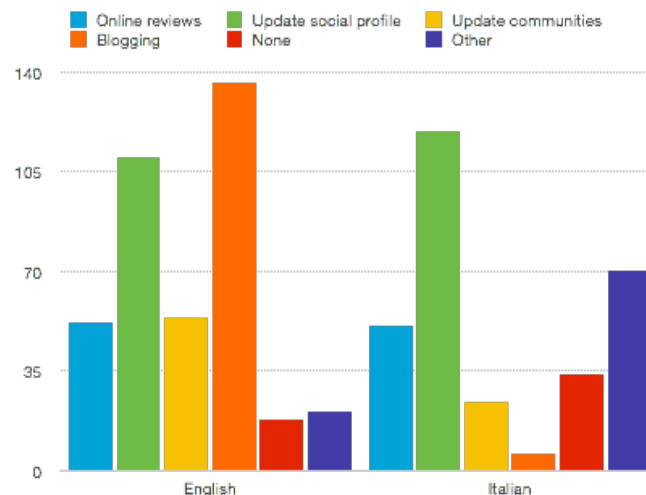


Fig.12 Content produced after travel in the two samples

In the final section, people explained their answers and gave some interesting hints as to the reasons behind them. Some of the comments indicate that there is a perceived difference among holidays and short break. Some respondents comment that their answers would have been different if the questionnaire topic was “short-break culture” instead of “travel culture”. Among the other comments, it is interesting to report that some users track their trips in unexplored routes using geo-reference tags with smartphones, checking in, for interesting places using tools such as Foursquare (www.foursquare.com). One respondent stated that technology increases people’s awareness although curiosity and interest are not provided by technology but belong to each of us. Digital is seen as an additional tool to explore the world. From personal comments, information sources reliability and contents curation emerged as the most relevant aspects, though believed to belong to traditional publications rather than digital ones. Interestingly, some users criticized smartphones and the Internet for distracting travellers from experiencing their trips properly.

3.2 Focus group

A sample of volunteers was recruited throughout the Italian web-based questionnaire to participate in a qualitative observation using the method of a focus-group, a technique which generates data through the opinions expressed by participants. This method allows the conductor to operate in complete transparency, declaring the purpose of the study and involving volunteer participants. This method has been used to examine narratives, which emerged during the observation. The interviews were based on the structure of the web-based questionnaire and the stages identified in the travel cycle. Survey participants who agreed to be contacted for the session were invited to fill a Doodle poll in order to schedule a date for the focus group session. Among volunteers available at the same time, eight participants were selected in order to represent different demographics and types of travellers.

The session took place at the library of the Association Angolo dell’Avventura in Rome (Italy). Among the participants, only two had not answered the questionnaire but were asked to join the study. The age of the participants was between 26 and 57 years old. The majority was female (5 of 8), three of them were active members of the

hosting association and tour operator coordinators.

The other participants ranged from infrequent to moderate travellers coming from different backgrounds and the youngest side of the sample. The session opened with a general discussion in which they were invited to express the reasons for their interest in joining the project and their expectations regarding the focus group. They were provided with an information sheet and a consent form providing all the relevant information concerning the purpose of the meeting and the treatment of their personal data.

Introduction

The title given to the research is “If Marco Polo had a blog: travel culture in the digital age”. Those participants who had already answered the questionnaire said they were attracted by the topic (i.e. travel) and were curious since with the spread of Internet and digital tools, they had experienced personally significant changes (3 of 8). The rest of the participants had no specific reason but were generally interested in the idea of being involved in a focus group and in the subject (5 of 8). The participants were invited to introduce themselves and to give a personal definition of the concept of travel (Table 2).

Focus Group Demographic

	Age range	Gender	Education	Traveler classification
Participant 1	31-40	Female	Bachelor degree	moderate
Participant2	26-30	Male	Bachelor degree	from moderate to high
Participant 3	56-65	Female	Master Degree	Frequent traveler □
Participant 4	41-55	Female	Master Degree	Frequent traveler
Participant 5	31-40	Male	Bachelor degree	Rare traveler
Participant 6	26-30	Female	Master Degree	moderate
Participant 7	31-40	Male	Master Degree	moderate
Participant 8	56-65	Female □	Master Degree	Frequent traveler □

Table 2. Demographic of Focus Group participants

Travel is generally perceived as a strong emotional experience, a source for new ideas and inspirations but also a means to relax and escape from conventions. Furthermore travel is seen as a lifestyle and fundamental part of living. Half of the participants defined themselves as budget travellers and three of them as frequent travellers undertaking long-haul trips at least 4 times per year. One participant stated that they were more interested in holidays than in travel, although the displacement from one place to another is also a fundamental feature of a holiday.

Inspiration and choice of destination

Inspiration is the first stage in the travel process. It came out that participants were sometimes not aware of this process. Some participants follow their instincts and often get inspiration from books (not necessary travel books) or pictures. Others genuinely declared that their decision is mainly reliant on the budget but

simultaneously dependent on personal interest. In these cases the main sources of inspiration are communities such as Zingarate (www.zingarate.it). One user declared that she plans her trips using Skyscanner, which allows her to know the cheapest destinations in a given period and subsequently that she reads books to inspire her choice of final destination. Word of mouth is the first source only for 2 of 8, whereas in another case it was the reliability on tour operators. In one case, Facebook groups were the first source of information because they provide immediate feedback by tourists.

Participant 1	Word of mouth, budget, bookshops, Skyscanner
Participant 2	Books
Participant 3	No internet, FB groups
Participant 4	Books, images
Participant 5	Budget
Participant 6	Budget, on line Communities
Participant 7	Books, web, forum
Participant 8	No internet

Tab 3. Focus group inspiration and destination choice sources

Organization

Although with different levels of influence and awareness, the Internet seems to be the first tool used to organize a journey. Google Maps seems to be one of the most favorite tools, alongside reviews, and websites such as TripAdvisor. For expert travellers, in 2 cases out of 3 the reliability of paper travel guides such as Lonely Planet or Guide Routard comes before the Internet. When they refer to the Internet, they specifically rely on forums and in particular on the Lonely Planet forum Thorn Tree. One coordinator declared that the Internet has completely changed her way of organizing the journey, as she does not use travel guides any further. The increasing trend of searching for information on the web is actually a factor, which increases the access to the travel guide publisher websites.

Participant 1	Internet, travel guidebooks, local info, apps
Participant 2	Books
Participant 3	Maps, Tripadvisor
Participant 4	Books, images, guidebooks
Participant 5	Internet, reviews
Participant 6	Internet, travel guidebooks
Participant 7	Internet, travel guidebooks, maps
Participant 8	No internet

Tab 4. Focus group travel organization tools

Travelling

Even the youngest declared that they prefer not to use Internet when travelling. They preferred to refer to local travel guides or talk to local people (if travelling in cities). A portion of the group declares that using digital tools such as smartphones, and in particular having access to an Internet connection, is something that distracts people from the spirit of the travel. They refer especially to something defined as a hunger of sharing and appearing on the social networks, which is even stronger than the will to enjoy the journey itself. The same is thought for pictures. On the other hand, just a couple of them admit to share through their social media profiles most significant pictures or tips about visited places. One participant likes to carry paper travel guides and to take notes, as well as collecting receipts, tickets and other souvenirs. However, someone found it useful to have a smartphone and access to Google maps when visiting a town.

Participant 1	Internet, travel guidebooks, local info, apps
Participant 2	No digital
Participant 3	Tablet offline contents, maps, paper guidebooks
Participant 4	Google maps
Participant 5	Internet, reviews
Participant 6	Internet, travel guidebooks
Participant 7	Internet, travel guidebooks, maps
Participant 8	Travel guides

Tab 5. Focus group devices and contents used in travel

Return

There are some participants who create special collections of pictures, publishing albums in Picasa, creating videos on YouTube channels, sharing folders on Dropbox, creating professional DVDs to be shared with travel mates and communities (association). With more difficulties they admit that they participate online in writing reviews in online communities such as TripAdvisor and spotting errors or changes in the forum and in particular with ThornTree. Many of them buy ebooks and books inspired by the experience. Some like to reproduce the flavours and the cuisine. Others write stories and love to share these with friends and family. It is interesting to notice that those who write reviews for TripAdvisor do so when the reviews are negative. Finally, participants were invited to express their thoughts on what a digital environment could really provide for tourists. They agreed on a Google system, but

specific for travel.

Participant 1	Photo, share experience with family & friends
Participant 2	Memoirs, souvenir collection, photo
Participant 3	Photo sharing on Picasa and Facebook
Participant 4	Travel literature, Photosharing (Picasa, Flickr)
Participant 5	Online reviews (TripAdvisor)
Participant 6	Photo
Participant 7	Update Social profiles, share experience with family and friends
Participant 8	Photo, Forum

Tab 6. Focus group contents produced returning from travel

3.3 Relevant findings

This study was an attempt to define some of the most common trends in travellers' behaviours, which might reflect the changes occurring in travel publishing. The results proved to be contradictory, partly due to the structure of the research and partially due to a general hostility and lack of awareness in identifying digital tools and the Internet as influential tools. The factor of the reliability on publishers seems to confirm that we are not facing the death of print rather than publishers who are instead expected to adapt and transform their contents into more usable and effective ways (Seoane, 2012, p.14).

Today, immediacy is very relevant. In fact, people are used to find information now and not tomorrow although they would eventually find the time to visit a bookshop and then search through a book for what they need. Travellers require really functional guide on the ground, one that they can interact with and which "gives them the perfect trip" (Schratz, 2012).

The sample of participants in the focus group was quite varied in regards to age and travel frequency, and this stood alongside the bias due to the fact that the questionnaire was submitted only via web suggesting that respondents had at least a basic familiarity with the web and the digital devices. However, it is interesting to note that compared to the findings of the web survey, focus groups participants were reluctant to admit the influence of the internet on the process. Smartphones emerged as the most common devices carried along, whereas in terms of influence guidebooks maintained a primacy. Participants stressed the complex nature of travel suggesting a digital platform highly semantic and intuitive in a Google style tailored for travel. Although they tend to write online reviews and get involved in specialised forums such as Thorn Tree, their approach towards other users recommendation is often

skeptical. Comparing the two research methods, the questionnaire was shown to be more specifically structured in gathering information on travel contents, whereas the focus group raised more practical issues especially relating to budget, interpersonal relationships with travel mates and a general pureness of travel as a personal experience not to be shared, although in contradiction with the trend of providing online recommendations. Nevertheless the impact of the Internet in the digitisation of contents in the form of ebooks proved to be irrelevant. What is seen as influential is a new way of producing travel contents which electronically converts word of mouth, and is reliable thanks to maps and multimedia. Travel emerges as a very rational action whereas other factors linked to leisure reading are not considered relevant for the process, despite functioning as sources of inspiration.

The message emerging from user interaction and their answer therefore, is the desire of staying focused, accurate and in touch consistently with the three features of travel information in the digital age. Possible advices for digital publishing could be to identify user needs, providing them with tools focused on accuracy and to encourage the sharing of interests and recommendations.

PROVIDE RAW NUMBERS

CHAPTER 4

4.1 The digital r/evolution of travel contents

In an information-intense industry such that of tourism, the accessibility of travel information is significantly influenced by the technological transformations (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010).

In fact, the acceptance of products and services in virtual environments has significantly enabled the use of technology to access information. Particularly, travel information is increasingly accessed via mobile devices and applications including maps, location recognition, augmented reality, spatially referenced User Generated Content (UGC) and location based services (Parra-Lopez et al., 2011, p.644). Moreover, the role played by social media in the ways people gather data on a destination is increasingly influential. UGC are growing exponentially and becoming the major source used at certain stages of the travel cycle such as planning and selecting places to visit and things to do.

The publishing industry has proved to be too slow in embracing innovation in digital travel content. However, the ability of gathering and organizing information unique to travellers' needs, which once, was the sole right of traditional travel publishers, has become a task also of communities, tourism firms and bloggers. There are huge opportunities for publishers to embrace the digital, becoming more innovative and playful with content, harnessing the internet, and overcoming challenges in information presentation and interactivity (Gretzel et al., 2000), so as to offer exciting new capabilities and services to readers (Henshall, 2012b).

Digital technologies are making the experience of travel, intuitive and personal (Reid, 2013) thus, there is an increasing concern over the role played by the stories which

travellers like and the way content is curated. Furthermore, game companies, broadcasters and internet developers, are entering into publishing to help travel companies to create digital storytelling projects for the travel cycle promoting recommendations and engagement (Henshall, 2012c).

The increasing predominance of personalization is influencing digital developments in tourism (Skyscanner, 2014) and creating new relevant challenges for travel publishers and storytelling. According to Skyscanner, in 10 years' time the era of time-consuming online travel discovery, research and booking across multiple platforms and devices will be long gone. In the near future, there is going to be a mass-market conversion to semantic data sets and Big Data which are going to be transformative for travellers but at the same time will require new ways of being visualized (Skyscanner, 2014). In such a scenario, where travel and tourism websites are prominent and it is more difficult for the industry to turn lookers into travellers, optimizing keywords may come into play (Pearo and Carroll, 2011). Content marketing and curation are crucial for web players, whereby travel industry is encouraging digital innovation in travel storytelling. Therefore, publishers should respond efficiently and effectively with constant innovation in the application of hardware, software, and networks. It is crucial to assess the requirements of their stakeholders, providing up to date travel contents available in multiple devices (Schratz, 2012).

The ability of providing contents in a coherent way is remarkable since search engines such as Google and Yahoo can be limited by their complexity (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010) conditioning discoverability. The computational analysis of contents using techniques of text mining and the semantic web is fundamental to interpret user reviews and consumer sentiments in order to evaluate services and to develop new digital editorial products including apps and websites (Vinod, 2010) specifically curated in order to answer the audience's demand for personalization and experience (Dale, 2011). Furthermore, writing contents is an effective way for brands to manage their presence across platforms in order to communicate, engage in conversations and draw the attention of potential travellers (Fong and Burton, 2006).

Unlike offline information, Travel 2.0 encourages interaction between travellers, with the "wisdom of the crowd" changing the way they organize their trips, track their trips and experience them. A review included or having been omitted could be remarkable in shaping travellers' perception of a destination and influencing their choices. Therefore, the branding and authority of the online database in eWom websites should be of the highest repute (Wills and Wills, 1996). Moreover, the major contribution electronic publishing offers the reader is the access to relevant archives worldwide and current browsing services anytime, anywhere with printing being available on demand.

This study has shown that travellers are more likely to use print and digital sources together such as traditional guidebook in the planning stage and a smartphone app for on the ground exploration. Moreover, the arrival of ePub3.0 could be very interesting for travel guides. In fact, this format has a script interface which uses scalable vector graphics allowing new complex components and interaction such as travel quizzes and metadata/geo-coding to enhance local detail and travel experiences (Henshall, 2012b). The digital publishing landscape allows publishers to seize these

opportunities, saving money on printing, warehousing and distributing books, offering readers smarter ways to experience travel.

Benefits in using digital technologies on vacation trips are significant albeit conditioned by the audiences and their familiarity with technologies (Parra-Lopez et al., 2011, p.641). Furthermore, the kind of tools a traveller requires depends also on the destination and the availability of electricity and Internet connection.

Although technologies are erasing traditional mediators in travel sector and encouraging a growing production of travel contents, the sector might face a “shock of contents” (Gonzalo, 2014). In order to keep travel contents effective, publishers and the other producers are required to develop accurate curation strategies.

4.2 TRAVOOL: a platform to access travel information

From the research conducted a huge global demand for travel information emerges, together with the issue that very few sources are both comprehensive and non-commercial. The process of searching information is very complex and involves the use of different devices and contents. A model is designed, for integration and organization of travel information across a variety of sources both online and offline. Among the digital devices, smartphones seem to be used more often than other, on the various stages of travel. Therefore, a mobile website responsive for smartphones, seems to be the most useful tool to model data gathered. Mobile versions of websites, compatible with mobile devices, allow users to access specialized information searches, to download and purchase contents and services, search through images, or filter search parameters and create itineraries across desktop and mobile devices. Furthermore, they enable social networking and navigation. The demand for richer and personalized web user experience encourages the introduction of different coding languages in order to integrate multimedia and web interfaces.

Mobile websites are based on HTML5, an alternative applications technology to native apps. Hypertext Markup Language (HTML) is the predominant markup language for the web and an essential building tool to organise and display content on the internet (Pilgrim, 2014). The advantages on using mobile websites rather than native apps are several. Native travel apps are an expensive tool based on proprietary plug-ins especially focused on immediacy and geo-localisation more than in guiding users in a more in-depth, rich, compelling and reflective read (Henshall, 2012a). On the other hand, HTML5 has the ability to integrate video, audio and other multi-media without the use of proprietary plug-ins. The cost of app maintenance and app updating is also higher for native apps, especially if this app supports more than one mobile platform whereas web apps are much easier to maintain, as they only require content to be uploaded onto a central web-source. CSS Stylesheets can be added in order to enable users to retrieve web contents specifically catered to fit their user interface, be it a smartphone, desktop or tablet to enhance the user browsing experience (Pilgrim, 2014).

Since search is a big component of the travel decision-making process, having a HTML5 mobile optimised site makes sense. Users are more likely to access such a site and if they see relevant information presented in a user-friendly way, the need for an app is reduced. However, users may sometimes find it difficult to discover a web

app, as it is not systematically listed in any app store (Pilgrim, 2014).

In travel information both online and offline sources are remarkable. HTML5 allows to access offline contents, which can be previously download when a device is online. An offline web application is a list of URLs — HTML, CSS, JavaScript, images, etc. The home page of the offline web application points to this list, which is called “manifest file”, according to Pilgrim: “a text file located elsewhere on the web server. A web browser that implements HTML5 offline applications will read the list of URLs from the manifest file, download the resources, cache them locally, and automatically keep the local copies up to date as they change. When travellers access the web application without a network connection, the web browser will automatically switch over to the local copies instead. This offline web application is very useful for accessing large amounts of contents” (Pilgrim, 2014).

HTML5 is able to perform several of the same tasks as an app such as: information sharing, creating a booking engine with payment capabilities and even multi-language function. However, if the main focus, is to take advantage of free notification services (relying on Wi-Fi or a data plan), then it makes more sense to create an app as HTML5 lags on some of the native features a phone can provide such as providing notifications, some aspects of location-based services and camera functionality (Pilgrim, 2014).

The purpose of this model is to overcome the conflict between digital travel information sources and traditional publishing beyond the common approach of the commercial tourism industry, delivering travel contents according to potential traveller’s indications.

The assumption is that digital publishers as curators of contents can harness digital evolution and create new product as requested by users. Although the data collected showed that individuals prefer to use other devices rather than smartphones to search for travel information and inspiration, they appear as the devices most habitually used during travel. This is a consequence of their capability of providing instant information support which enables tourists to solve problems, share experiences and store memories (Wang et al., 2012). Therefore this wireframe refers to a web app. a website built with HTML5, optimised for another device.

The mobile website intends to deliver a unique experience by offering background information and context, gorgeous photography, and ideas for constructing trips that are highly customized. In fact, the ideal travel publication emerging from this research is that of a dynamic platform enabling users to access information when they are connected and at the same time providing an HTML5 offline functionality to access contents when there is no internet connection available.

The mental map designed sums up the respondents’ processes in travel information and organization, as they emerged in this study (fig.14). Respondents access different types of travel contents both online and offline. Most influential inspiration sources are contents as travel books and Internet contents together with the word of mouth of peers. During the organization phase, there is a significant request for practical tips in the form of personal and experiential recommendations. These sources online take the shape of blogs and user generated contents, (i.e. forum, TripAdvisor). It reveals the increasing relevance of personalized information rather than flat contents as those

present in traditional travel guides. Among the activities taken by respondents pictures and videos are the most common way to create travel storytelling. Furthermore, travel video usage is also a remarkable mean of inspiration whereas pictures that communicate messages of destinations, programs, and activities are crucial to attract and hold potential visitors, stimulating word of mouth (Li, n.d.p.35).

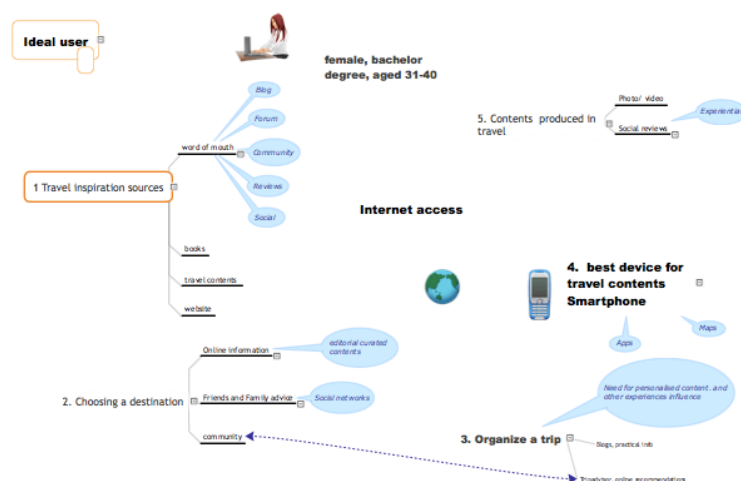


Fig. 14. Mind Map – Lara mental model emerging from questionnaire feedback and the focus group BETTER RESOLUTION

As it has been observed in Chapter 3, the access to reliable information is the most relevant need expressed among respondents. To this extent, a mobile website in HTML5 is proposed because this technology focuses on delivering curated information and accessing large amounts of data (big data) allowing the users to undertake semantic research and improve their travel experience (Pilgrim, 2014) in an easy and inexpensive way. Big data is crucial in travel industry where the semantic web is used to allow websites to recommend a specific hotel or a specific itinerary based on users preferences. The current scenario lacks of a specific semantic tool used to access and visualize big data related to travel editorial contents.

Focus groups participant to this study revealed that the sum of their information request could be accomplished by developing a travel search engine specific for travel contents. Moreover, the interaction among travellers and communities emerged as a crucial feature determining the modeling of a “participated travel search engine” which integrates Travel 2.0 and travel publishing. This model borrows some features from existing websites such as Google, integrating semantic technology, Api and users generated contents (Recker, 2014).

This research hypothesis is that a digital travel publisher might embrace this model to give more visibility to its brand through an effective tool addressing the request of personalised travel information. Based on the semantic search principles of Google,

the search engine TRAVOOL displays travel related information getting rid of non-relevant contents. The dataset is made up by the publisher products and with the participation of users and other partners (publishers, libraries, etc.), which are enabled to add links to travel contents. TRAVOOL works as a link aggregator moderated by the publisher, which selects relevant contents and reliable sources. It is inspired by the Italian platform Liquida (<http://segnalablog.liquida.it>) whereby in addition, it provides an editorial control over contents.

Furthermore, users contribute to generate TRAVOOL contents uploading photos, videos and engaging in forum discussions. Among its sources, the search engine uses Api to access customized contents from the most remarkable websites in the world of travel 2.0 such as Trip Advisor (to make users review appear on search results), Tripit (to display relevant itineraries), Viaggiart – www.viaggiart.it (an Italian platform collecting culture heritage landmarks), Vayable – www.vayable.com (displaying personalized itineraries), Cookening – www.cookening.com (for foodies experiences with locals). Api (application programming interface) allows TRAVOOL to easily interface with third platforms querying their databases to provide relevant information. Finally, the publisher is responsible for curating extra contents creating posts and addressing the reader towards certain topics. The use of HTML5 will allow to access offline contents previously accessed when online.

Designing the wireframe

Although the study highlights the presence of different audiences, to design a wireframe for this model an archetypal user is identified according to data gathered. The large majority of web-surveys respondents are female whereas the most represented age range is between 31 and 40. Hence, this Persona is a young woman called Lara aged between 31 and 40 with a bachelor's degree, working in the PR. She is digitally literate (as she is answering to a web-based survey) and has a one or more social media profiles. The questionnaire does not investigate whether she travels frequently or not. Therefore, we assume she is a moderate traveller as the most represented category among focus-group participants (Fig. 13).



Fig 13. The persona

The second step is the design of a user interface. According to Stone et al., a user interface is “That part of a computer system with which a user interacts in order to undertake her tasks and achieve her goals” (Stone, Jarrett et. al., 2001). A user interface should be kept as simple as possible. In order to be easily visualized in a smartphone, the homepage design is basically divided into 4 sections.

In the first section, TRAVOOL homepage will immediately refer to the customized search offered, inviting users to filter queries (and consequently the search results) for interests. Right after comes the UGC section inviting users to upload pictures, video and participate in the forum discussion.

The third section is for recommending and linking travel sources of information (including web travel contents and literary travel contents). The fourth section is that curated by the publisher and contains posts and other multimedia curated by the editorial staff. The GUI (graphic user interface) is kept very simple with more intuitive icons and images rather than text used to navigate.

The user starting a search in the home page is sent to a page of the results. Hence, the search is semantically declined across categories: contents, pictures, video, maps, itineraries, forum discussions, books/ebooks, foodie’s experiences and art landmarks. Only the categories containing relevant results are displayed. The final results integrate Api resources, UGC, proprietary publisher contents and every other relevant source added by partners, users and the editorial staff.

In order to visualise the basic functioning of the model a set of wireframes has been attached, which illustrates an example search through the Home page and the Search result page designed for desktop and smartphone. EXPLAIN WHY THIS IS THE BETTER APPROACH

4.3 Future development for the model

The publishing industry, which was one of the most flourishing industries after the Second World War, has encountered a significant crisis in the last years of the 20th Century (Wang and Xiang, 2012). The impact of disruptive technologies including digital tools and the Internet has found publishers unprepared while other players begin to produce and deliver useful contents for travellers. This model wants to show that trustworthiness and curation of contents are remarkable in a digital environment. In fact the digital curation requires contents producers to work as publishers selecting relevant and reliable contents, making them available and discoverable across various formats.

Digital publishing is a challenge for travel publisher and the other players in the production of travel contents, to engage in the development of travel narratives innovating and successfully collaborating with each other. The engagement with users and travel communities becomes essential to create brand loyalty and to allow travellers to access up-to date information. In the model proposed, the publisher might improve brand loyalty and discoverability of its contents providing an accurate curation of contents, harnessing the up-to-date nature of UGC offering at the same time a platform for everyone. In fact, the success of TRAVOOL brings traffic and increase reputation also for the other contents producers included in the network.

Further developments might be implemented in the platform, improving off line and exportability functionalities. In fact, digital allows contents to be available everywhere at any time. The rise of digital publishing formats such as ePub3 and its compatibility with most common devices including smartphones and e-readers, allow producers to deliver enhanced guides and travel books with multimedia and games, to download and store single chapters and customize contents using exportability functionalities to create their own publications in ePub and Pdf following the model of Wikivoyage (Patokallo, 2013).

In the near future, native digital apps might enhance their functionality and be developed and maintained more easily from publishers. The fact that participants to the study do not significantly rely in apps and geo localization services to plan their route derives from the current technological limitations. The integration between big data and native apps using location-based services (think Foursquare) combined with geo-referencing technologies (knowing when customers are near locations of interest to them) open up a whole world of possibilities. Consumers will become used to giving up some elements of their privacy in return for better personalization (Thang Dang et al., 2007). Moreover, publishers will be available to harness self-publishing platform for travellers. Recently, an app called Esplorio (<http://home.esplor.io>) has been launched in beta test to promote a different digital travel narration allowing users to create a digital travel journal using the app and his social media history.

Digital publishing might be used to promote cultural tourism in a familiar and attractive way. It can be used to go beyond cognitive barriers and erase the borders between travel and tourism, transforming both of them into tools for self-improvement and discovery of the world and its humanist and cultural heritage.

Back to the opening question: If Marco Polo had a blog how would he tell his story? There would probably be less controversy about the characters and animals he met. He might have used pictures and maps to better explain his route. At the same time, its exploration might have been conditioned to previous reviews missing some important landmarks. The digital is certainly influencing the travellers' processes of knowledge in terms of cultural experiences and production of sources, whereby it seems reductive to imagine one model for such a complex topic as that of travel. This study remarks that only imagination can limit the opportunities rising from the digital integration of travel contents.

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APPENDIX 1

Page 1 of 1

If Marco Polo had a Blog - Travel culture in the digital Age

Welcome!

The purpose of this study is to understand the current scenario in the production of travel related contents. In particular, the influence of internet and digital tools on building our personal travel culture, but also their coexistence with other traditional sources of the travel environment. To be eligible you must be at least 18 years old. Your data will not be identifiable and will be used exclusively for the purpose of this research. If you are interested please, answer this short questionnaire.

Feel free to contact me if you have any question arising from this form.

Thanks for your help:)

Giulio Carai

Gender

- ☐ Female
- ☐ Male
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Education

- ☐ Did not complete High School
- ☐ High School/GED
- ☐ Some College
- ☐ Bachelor's Degree
- ☐ Master's Degree
- ☐ Advanced graduate work or Ph.D.
- ☐ Not sure

About you

Your participation is anonymous and voluntary

Age Group

- ☐ 18-25
- ☐ 26-30
- ☐ 31-40
- ☐ 41-55
- ☐ 56-65
- ☐ over 65

Occupation

Travel Inspiration

Inspiration sources

Which one of these sources have influenced your decision to undertake a journey?*

- ☐ Book
- ☐ Ebook
- ☐ Magazine
- ☐ Film
- ☐ Advertising (tv/radio/press)
- ☐ TV Documentary
- ☐ Web Documentary
- ☐ Web Advertising
- ☐ Travel Website
- ☐ Word of mouth
- ☐ Other:

Inspiring sources - A scale

1 less influential, 5 more influential

	1	2	3	4	5
Book	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Ebook	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Magazine	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Film	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Advertising (TV/Radio/Press)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
TV Documentary	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Web Documentary	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Web Advertising	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Travel Website	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Word of mouth	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Other	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Which one of these "places" have inspired your decision to undertake a journey*



- ☐ Library
- ☐ Bookstore/News-stand
- ☐ On line Travel Forum
- ☐ E-bookstore
- ☐ Museum
- ☐ Societies
- ☐ Travel website/Community
- ☐ Internet
- ☐ Cinema/Theatre
- ☐ Other:

Inspiring places - A scale

1 less influential, 5 more influential

	1	2	3	4	5
Library	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Bookstores/News-stand	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
On line Travel Forum	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
E-bookstore	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Museum	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Societies	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Travel website/Community	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Internet	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Cinema/Theatre	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Choose your next travel destination

The process towards the final choice

How do you choose your next travel destination?*

- ☐ Asking advice to local travel societies in your town
- ☐ Asking for community advice on-line (TripAdvisor, Forums, Social Media)
- ☐ Searching for information on the internet
- ☐ Asking for family/friends' advice
- ☐ Go to a travel agency (both on line and off line)
- ☐ Other:

Choosing - A scale

1 less influential, 5 more influential

	1	2	3	4	5
Asking advice to local travel societies in your town	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Asking for community advice on-line (TripAdvisor, Forums, Social Media)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Searching for information on the internet	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Asking for family/friends' advice	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Go to a travel agency (both on line and off line)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Go to a travel agency (both on line and off line)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Other	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Organize your journey

Useful tools to plan your trips

Which tools do you use to organise a journey?*

- ☐ I buy a brand new travel guide and start to underline
- ☐ Refer to on-line recommendations (travel blog, forum, influencers)
- ☐ Refer to user generated reviews (TripAdvisor, etc)
- ☐ Refer to travel communities on-line
- ☐ Buy travel books
- ☐ Download travel ebooks
- ☐ Download smartphone travel apps
- ☐ Get in touch with travel societies in your town
- ☐ Ask for your family/friends' help
- ☐ Other:

Tools used - A scale

1 less influential, 5 more influential



	1	2	3	4	5
Brand new travel guide	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
On-line recommendations (travel blog, forum, influencers)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
User generated reviews (TripAdvisor, etc)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Travel communities on-line	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Travel books	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Travel ebooks	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Smartphone travel apps	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Travel societies in your town	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Your family/friends' help	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Other	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Which contents do you produce when you travel?*



- ☐ I write on-line reviews
- ☐ I update my social media profiles
- ☐ I constantly post updates in on-line communities
- ☐ I update my blog
- ☐ I write a journal
- ☐ I take pictures/video
- ☐ None
- ☐ Other:

Contents in travel - A scale

1 less frequent, 5 more frequent

	1	2	3	4	5
On-line reviews	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Update social media profiles	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Constantly post updates in on-line communities	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Update my blog	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Write a journal	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Take pictures/video	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
None	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Other	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Back home

Things you do when your journey is over

Which contents do you produce once back home?*

- ☐ I write on-line reviews
- ☐ I update my social profile with pictures etc
- ☐ I share my experience with communities and forums
- ☐ I write my blog, memoirs
- ☐ None
- ☐ Other:

Contents back home - A scale

1 less frequent, 5 more frequent

	1	2	3	4	5
On-line reviews	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Update social media profiles	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
share my experience with communities and forums	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I write my blog, memoirs	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
None	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Other	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Please report any other suggestions/opinions/personal experiences

Thank You!

APPENDIX 2

Research Ethics Office
King's College London
Rm 5.2 FWB (Waterloo Bridge Wing)
Stamford Street
London
SE1 9NH

14 April 2014

TO: Giuseppina Carai

SUBJECT: Approval of ethics application

Dear Giuseppina,

KCL/13/14-334 - "If Marco Polo had a blog". The travel culture in a Digital Age

I am pleased to inform you that full approval for your project has been granted by the **A&H** Research Ethics Panel. Any specific conditions of approval are laid out at the end of this letter which should be followed in addition to the standard terms and conditions of approval, to be overseen by your Supervisor:

- Ethical approval is granted for a period of **one year** from **14 April 2014**. You will not receive a reminder that your approval is about to lapse so it is your responsibility to apply for an extension prior to the project lapsing if you need one (see below for instructions).
- You should report any untoward events or unforeseen ethical problems arising from the project to the panel Chairman within a week of the occurrence. Information about the panel may be accessed at:
<http://www.kcl.ac.uk/innovation/research/support/ethics/committees/sshl/reps/index.aspx>
- If you wish to change your project or request an extension of approval, please complete the Modification Proforma. A signed hard copy of this should be submitted to the Research Ethics Office, along with an electronic version to crec-lowrisk@kcl.ac.uk. Please be sure to quote your low risk reference number on all correspondence. Details of how to fill a modification request can be found at:
<http://www.kcl.ac.uk/innovation/research/support/ethics/applications/modifications.aspx>
- All research should be conducted in accordance with the King's College London *Guidelines on Good Practice in Academic Research* available at:
<http://www.kcl.ac.uk/iop/research/office/help/Assets/good20practice20Sept200920FINAL.pdf>

If you require signed confirmation of your approval please email crec-lowrisk@kcl.ac.uk indicating why it is required and the address you would like it to be sent to.

Please would you also note that we may, for the purposes of audit, contact you from time to time to ascertain the status of your research.

We wish you every success with this work.

With best wishes

Annah Whyton – Research Support Assistant

On behalf of

A&H REP Reviewer